Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Robert Browning's "Verse-Making Was Least of My Virtues"

Literary concepts that **MIGHT** be used in a discussion of the persona's revealing of himself in Browning's "Verse-Making Was Least of My Virtues" include

abstract,
aphorism,
character,
cliché,
conceit,
concrete,
consonance,
irony,
rhyme scheme, and
tone.

The young writer should recognize that a comparison of writing poetry to courting a woman might have a few points of comparison, but the poem's persona is dwelling on what he perceives to be a significant set of differences. The contestant might address the tone of the persona's listing of these differences, the principle difference being the simplicity of love-making* in contrast to verse-writing.

The contestant might recognize in the persona's argument that courting a woman is easier than writing verse, an irony that points to his apparent failing to establish a long-term commitment. While writing poetry is indeed difficult—and he does admit to its being among the least of his virtues, he approaches the task with pragmatism, as settled in the aphoristic "To do little is bad, to do nothing is worse." The persona's second turn to aphorism, "To keep silence were folly," seems to put an easily attained goal Before the difficult journey described in the first stanza.

A further answer irony might be argued: the persona-as-poet will not "keep silence" (line 13) in his pursuit of love, apparently either without concern for the quality of the language or, perhaps, in a high self-estimation, his love-language never fails, and he never, apparently views this particular species of effort with despair, as he does verse-making (line1). One suspects that during the nineteenth-century love-making without language would have gotten he-who-would-woo nowhere, for language is often the vehicle by which affection is initialized. In short, the persona has unwittingly (or wittingly) revealed that he thinks that he is much better at courtship than at the writing of poetry, something at which he must actually work—especially if the poet wishes to write poetry that doesn't turn on cliché's.

*** the phrase "to make love" did not pick up its sexual connotation until mid-twentieth century**